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CNSA-156 PM

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Answer Files

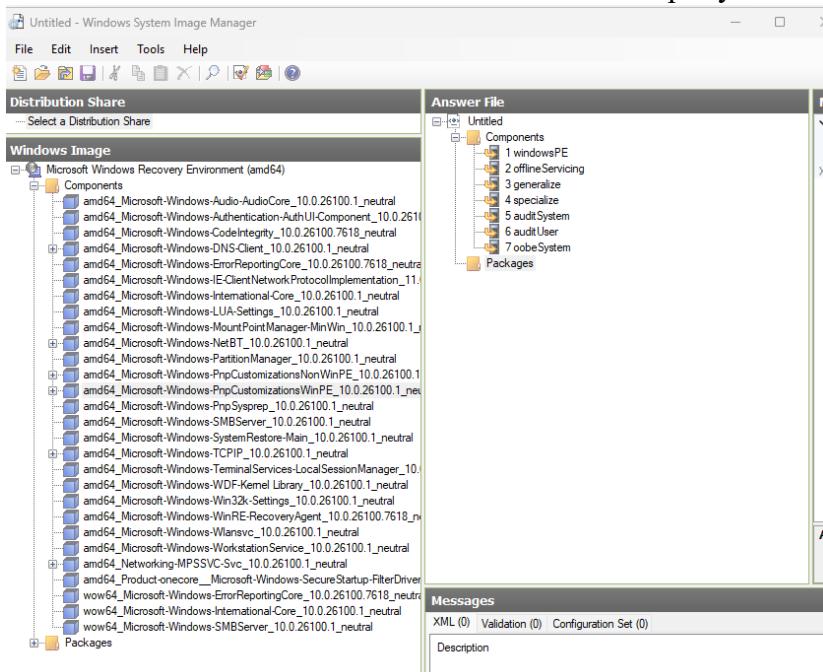
Scenario 1

Goal: Create an answer file that can be plugged in as bootable media, creating an administrator account with my name and CNSAacnsa1, as well as a 100 GB NTFS partition for the OS to install on.

1. I started by downloading Windows System Image Manager along with finding the Windows installation image
2. Finding the installation image was the first place that I ran into issues, as it wasn't

anywhere in my files that I looked. In the image on the right, you can see when I tried to find it through command line which also didn't work. I then had to go to Window's website to download it, which also didn't work, and I had to download the file off of a third-party site.

```
01/29/2026 01:34 PM <DIR> .
01/29/2026 01:32 PM <DIR> ..
04/01/2024 05:22 AM      3,170,304 boot.sdi
01/29/2026 01:34 PM      1,109 ReAgent.xml
01/29/2026 01:32 PM           0 SrSettings.ini
01/29/2026 01:27 PM    664,525,336 Winre.wim
                4 File(s)    667,696,749 bytes
                2 Dir(s)    120,508,416 bytes free
```



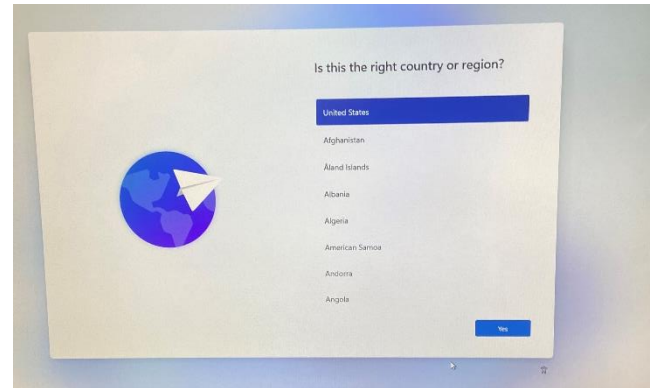
3. Once I had both things downloaded and ready, I uploaded the iso file into Window System Image Manager (which can be seen in the image to the left) and did research and how and which settings to change to make it work with all the required settings.

4. I downloaded that file into a .xml file named autounattend, putting it onto a flash drive.

5. I then put a blank SSD into my Custom PC and put the flash drive into one of the USB 3.0 slots. I turned on the PC to let it boot and it did not work.

6. The first time mine failed by booting into the BIOS because I hadn't put a bootable Windows 11 onto the same drive.

7. I tried again by putting the bootable Windows 11 onto my drive and putting the autounattend.xml back onto the flash drive. It failed again, getting to the disk partition screen before failing.
8. I then adjusted the .xml file's script within notepad making some changes on it, and my next attempt was stopped at the screen visible on the right during the installation.
9. After that time I changed strategies and went to schneegans.de, which is a website designed to create answer files for you while letting you adjust the settings you need to within it.



10. Within schneegans, I set up the settings that can be seen in the photos below, most of these are the defaults set in schneegans, the only things I changed, were checking the box that says 'Bypass Windows 11 requirements check (TPM Secure Boot, etc.)', setting my time zone explicitly, using '(UTC-5:00) Eastern Time (US & Canada)', choosing to use a custom disk part script having it create a partition primary size=102400, making the administrator account named Joseph with it's password set as CNSAcnsal, and having it 'skip wi-fi configuration' and then scrolling to the bottom and choosing 'download .xml file'

Setup settings:

- ☒ Bypass Windows 11 requirements check (TPM, Secure Boot, etc.)
- ☐ Allow Windows 11 to be installed without internet connection
⚠ Only check this option if your computer really does not have internet access. You will still have to click the *I don't have internet* button during Windows Setup in that case. If you just want to create local ("offline") user accounts in Windows 11, you do **not** need this option – simply use the *User accounts* section of this form.
- ☐ Use a distribution share / configuration set
This makes Windows Setup look for a folder named `$OEM$` in the root of the drive where your `autounattend.xml` file is located and [copy its contents to the target partition](#).

Time zone:

- ☐ Let Windows determine your time zone based on language and region settings
- ☒ Set your time zone explicitly
This is useful when your country or region spans multiple time zones, like Australia or the United States.
Use this time zone: (UTC-05:00) Eastern Time (US & Canada)

Partitioning and formatting:

- ☐ Partition the disk interactively during Windows Setup
- ☐ Let Windows Setup wipe, partition and format your hard drive (more specifically, disk 0) using these settings:
 - ☐ Choose partition layout
 - ☐ Remove Windows RE
This will delete the `C:\Recovery` folder and thus free about 600 MB of disk space. No recovery partition will be created.
Windows 24H2 seems to ignore this setting and will always create a recovery partition with a minimum size of 600 MB.
 - ☒ Use a custom `diskpart` script to configure your disk(s):

```
SELECT DISK=0
CLEAN
CONVERT GPT
CREATE PARTITION EFI SIZE=300
FORMAT QUICK FS=FAT32 LABEL="System"
ASSIGN LETTER=S
CREATE PARTITION MSR SIZE=16
CREATE PARTITION PRIMARY SIZE=102400
SHRINK MINIMUM=1000
FORMAT QUICK FS=NTFS LABEL="Windows"
ASSIGN LETTER=W
CREATE PARTITION PRIMARY
FORMAT QUICK FS=NTFS LABEL="Recovery"
ASSIGN LETTER=R
SET ID="de94bb4-06d1-4d40-a16a-bfd50179d6ac"
GPT ATTRIBUTES=0x0000000000000001
```

User accounts:

☒ Let Windows Setup create the following local ("offline") accounts:

Account name	Display name	Password	Group
Joseph		CNSAcnsa1	Administrators ▼
			Users ▼
			Users ▼
			Users ▼
			Users ▼

WLAN / Wi-Fi setup:

☐ Configure Wi-Fi interactively during Windows Setup

☒ Skip Wi-Fi configuration

Choose this if you have a wired connection to the internet.

☐ Configure Wi-Fi using these settings:

Network name (SSID):

Connect even if not broadcasting: ☐

- I then put a copy of the .xml file onto the drive that has the bootable media on it, then put it into the custom with a blank SSD and turn the PC. It will go through the whole windows installation process without having to press anything, and it should leave you on the Windows 11 home screen already signed into your account.

Scenario 2

Goal: Create an answer file to automate the questions during the imaging and cloning process. Setting it up so that any new account created on the PC will also get some settings predetermined.

- To start on this scenario, I started with the drive that I had used for scenario 1, meaning it had windows 11 installed on it already.
- I then researched and found that I needed an autounattend like this

```
k?xml version="1.0" encoding="utf-8"?>
<unattend xmlns="urn:schemas-microsoft-com:unattend">
  <settings pass="specialize">
    <component name="Microsoft-Windows-Shell-Setup" processorArchitecture="amd64" publicKeyToken="31bf3856ad364e35" language="neutral" versionScope="nonSxS" xmlns:wcm="http://schemas.microsoft.com/WMIConfig/2002/State"
      xmlns:xs="http://www.w3.org/2001/XMLSchema-instance">
      <CopyProfile>true</CopyProfile>
      <TimeZone>Eastern Standard Time</TimeZone>
    </component>
    <component name="Microsoft-Windows-Deployment" processorArchitecture="amd64" publicKeyToken="31bf3856ad364e35" language="neutral" versionScope="nonSxS" xmlns:wcm="http://schemas.microsoft.com/WMIConfig/2002/State"
      xmlns:xs="http://www.w3.org/2001/XMLSchema-instance">
      <RunSynchronous>
        <RunSynchronousCommand wcm:action="add">
          <Order>1</Order>
          <Path>net user Administrator /active:Yes</Path>
          <WillReboot>Never</WillReboot>
        </RunSynchronousCommand>
        <RunSynchronousCommand wcm:action="add">
          <Order>2</Order>
          <Path>net user Administrator CNSAcnsa1</Path>
          <WillReboot>Never</WillReboot>
        </RunSynchronousCommand>
      </RunSynchronous>
    </component>
  </settings>
  <settings pass="oobeSystem">
    <component name="Microsoft-Windows-International-Core" processorArchitecture="amd64" publicKeyToken="31bf3856ad364e35" language="neutral" versionScope="nonSxS" xmlns:wcm="http://schemas.microsoft.com/WMIConfig/2002/State"
      xmlns:xs="http://www.w3.org/2001/XMLSchema-instance">
      <InputLocale>0409:00000409</InputLocale>
      <SystemLocale>en-US</SystemLocale>
      <UILanguage>en-US</UILanguage>
      <UILanguageFallback>en-US</UILanguageFallback>
      <UserLocale>en-US</UserLocale>
    </component>
    <component name="Microsoft-Windows-Shell-Setup" processorArchitecture="amd64" publicKeyToken="31bf3856ad364e35" language="neutral" versionScope="nonSxS" xmlns:wcm="http://schemas.microsoft.com/WMIConfig/2002/State"
      xmlns:xs="http://www.w3.org/2001/XMLSchema-instance">
      <TimeZone>Eastern Standard Time</TimeZone>
      <OOBE>
        <HideEULAPage>true</HideEULAPage>
        <HideLocalAccountScreen>true</HideLocalAccountScreen>
        <HideOEMRegistrationScreen>true</HideOEMRegistrationScreen>
        <HideOnlineAccountScreens>true</HideOnlineAccountScreens>
        <HideWirelessSetupInOOBE>true</HideWirelessSetupInOOBE>
        <NetworkLocation>Home</NetworkLocation>
        <ProtectYourPC>3</ProtectYourPC>
        <SkipMachineOOBE>true</SkipMachineOOBE>
        <SkipUserOOBE>true</SkipUserOOBE>
      </OOBE>
    </component>
  </settings>
</unattend>
```

- I put that file into my sysprep folder on my c: drive, the exact path is C:\Windows\System32\Sysprep
- I downloaded google, but any program will work, tossing it onto my desktop
- Once the file was in the folder, I ran sysprep in oobe mode with generalize turned on
- The first time it failed, so I wiped the drive, reinstalled windows 11 the same as before

7. I did the same thing, installing chrome onto my desktop and reran sysprep with the file in my sysprep folder
8. It worked, and I created a new account and checked its desktop, seeing google there to confirm that it had properly worked.